LAF YOMI

Bekhorot 41 · October 29, 2026

ON TODAY'S DAF

Bekhorot 41: the calf's tail and the ערכוב joint, then the middle category — blemishes barred from the Mizbeach yet not freed for the field. Plus Rashi vs. Rambam on lulav, dry vs. moist גרב, and a tumtum sugya left unresolved.

קפץ העליון · THE CALF'S TAIL AND THE CAMEL'S LANDMARK



1. To find the ערכוב — the joint that decides whether a calf's short tail is a mum — the baraita says: the upper joint, not the lower, 'and opposite it, by a camel, it is recognizable.' Rashi gives two pshatim.

“On one pshat, the camel walks around with a protruding bone marking the spot — nature's own survey peg. Just find a camel and read the joint off it.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 41a · the joint 'recognizable by a camel' · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 2:18

לא במקדש ולא במדינה · RASHI VS. RAMBAM ON THE LULAV MAP



2. The middle-category Mishnah says לא במקדש ולא במדינה — and Elefant notes the same words decide a Sukkot question: does lulav apply seven days outside the Temple? Rashi: מקדש is only the Beit HaMikdash, so without it nowhere has seven-day lulav d'Oraita. Rambam: מקדש is all of Yerushalayim.

“The mefarshim say our Mishnah backs Rashi — a korban can only be in the Beit HaMikdash — so the Rambam must hold that מקדש and מדינה mean different things in different masechtot. Same dictionary, different zip code.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 41a · לא במקדש ולא במדינה · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 8:35

מן הצאן · THREE מנS FOR זקן, חולה, מזוהם



3. Why three separate מנs for the old, the sick and the foul-smelling? Each teaches something the others don't. Old age, says Elefant, never reverses — 'a זקן, once you're old you don't get younger again' — while a sick animal can recover.

“Sickness is a maybe; old age is a one-way street. Of the three, only ageing comes with no return policy — which is exactly why the Torah had to say it separately.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 41a · זקן דלא הדר בריא · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 22:57

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מזוהם · THE FOUL-SMELLING ANIMAL



4. מזוהם — an animal with a foul smell — sits in the middle category. Elefant: the Rishonim ask what happens if perfume removes the smell. Everybody agrees: if the perfume works, it is not מזוהם anymore.

“And some Rishonim go further — a smell that merely CAN be covered by perfume already doesn't count. A mum you can spray away isn't a mum: the Beit HaMikdash's first fragrance test.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 41a · מזוהם — unless the perfume works · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 13:33

מן הצאן · THE FLOCK THAT TRAVELS TOGETHER



5. From מן הצאן the baraita excludes מוקצה — an animal designated for idol worship. The Modzitzer Rebbe's vort, as Elefant tells it: צאן has no singular or plural — one sheep or a thousand, it is all צאן — because sheep travel together.

“And Klal Yisrael is the same: one nation, always together. So one who designates for avodah zarah has cut himself off from the flock — מן המוקצה — and that is why מן הצאן excludes him. Grammar as theology.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 41a · מן הצאן — the flock vort · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 27:35

אתא קרא למעוטי ספקא · DOES THE TORAH LEGISLATE FOR A MAYBE?



6. The Gemara tries to prove R' Yishmael's view from a baraita about olah: 'male, and not female' — said twice, so the second must exclude tumtum and androginos. But if the Tanna Kamma holds they are a safek, Elefant asks: need a verse to exclude a safek?

“הקדוש ברוך הוא has no safek, has no questions.' The Torah wasn't written by someone in doubt — so a verse can't be there just to exclude a maybe. The only party in the whole sugya who is never unsure is Hashem.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 41b · Hashem has no safek · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 42:03